and it was never directly involved in deals, it provided intelligence on suppliers and arms dealers operating in the global market.

Narasimhan's view that the R&AW is underutilised in this area is echoed by several other R&AW spies. The intelligence officials argue that R&AW officers are better trained to understand the shadowy world of arms dealing than a civilian bureaucrat posted abroad. And they could utilise their assets within the establishment of the target country to secure better deals. But they are shackled by the bureaucracy in many ways, including a turf war with the Indian Foreign Service (IFS). With a staff strength of about six thousand people, the spy agency finds it tough to maintain the cover of its agents abroad, particularly because of internal rivalries and a war with officers from diplomatic services.

An officer codenamed Alok Singh told me: 'In various instances, the diplomatic community exposed the identity of a R&AW officer within days of her or his arrival in the target country. In some cases, officers from other agencies inadvertently or deliberately identified the spy. Despite this pressure, the extraordinary men and women of the Indian intelligence community have done remarkable jobs. But the shackles need to be broken before R&AW can realise its full potential.'

For example, the arrival of a R&AW spy codenamed R.K. Singh in Dhaka sometime in the first week of June 1990 was disclosed to the Bangladeshi regime. Singh, whose primary task was to check Pakistan's sphere of influence in Bangladesh, learned from a junior officer at the embassy that his cover had been blown the moment he landed at Dhaka airport. From his first day at the embassy, he had been constrained in his tasks to